in transition. Several lineages became more territorial and settled in the Later Vedic Age. This is evidenced by the term *janapada,* as we saw earlier. The mid-first millennium BCE had political organisations such as *rajya* and *ganasanghas* (oligarchies) and these institutions developed in the later Vedic period.

Lineage is a group of people descended from a common ancestor.

As we saw earlier, the clans of Bharatas and Purus combined to form the Kurus, and along with the Panchalas they occupied the central part of the Ganga-Yamuna doab. Panchala territory was in north-western Uttar Pradesh. The Kuru-Panchalas became one major ethnic group and Hastinapur became their capital. The war between the Kauravas and Pandavas was the theme of the Mahabharata and both of them belonged to the clan of Kurus. Traditions say that Hastinapur was flooded and the Kuru clan moved to Kausambi near Allahabad.

Sacrifices and rituals gained importance in the Later Vedic society. The king became more independent. Rituals dominated kingship, and this increased the power and influence of the *Rajanyas* and the *Brahmanas*, while distancing the king from the *vis*. The *Asvamedha-yaga* involved letting a horse loose into areas where it moved freely; this was an assertion that the authority of the king was recognized, and a battle ensued when the horse was challenged. The *vajapeya* ritual involved a chariot race. Such innovative modes of rituals helped to increase the power of the king.

Social Organization

The social transformation in the Later Vedic Period is much more clearly reflected in the references in the Vedic texts. The social divisions of *varna* became more established. Teaching was seen as the occupation of the Brahmanas. The wives of Brahmanas and cows were given important status. *Rajanya* refers to *kshatriyas* and they were the warriors and rulers who received *bali* as tax.

Striking changes took place in the *Varna System.* There was an increase in the privileges of the two higher classes, the Brahmanas and the Kshatriyas at the cost of the Vaisyas and Sudras. In the *Panchavimsa Brahmana, the Kshatriya* is placed first, higher than the *Brahmana* but in the *Satapatha Brahmana,* the *Brahmana* is placed higher than *Kshatriya.* In later Vedic society the importance of the *purohita (*priest) is stressed, as mentioned in the Vedic texts. The Kshatriyas challenged Brahmanical supremacy and their exclusive privilege of entering the *asramas*, a regulated four stage life namely brahmacharya, grihasta, vanaprastha and sanyasa. The outcome of this was the birth of Jainism, Buddhism and Ajivakam.

The system of four Varnas had taken deep root and became rigid in the course of time. The popularity of rituals helped the *Brahmanas* to attain power. Brahmanas became important and the kings supported them, although they had conflicts with *Rajanyas*, the warrior nobles. The concept of *dvija* (twice-born) developed and the *upanayana* (sacred thread) was limited to the upper sections of the society. This ceremony marked the initiation for education. The fourth varna was denied this privilege and the Gayatri mantra could not be recited by the Sudras. Women were also denied upanayana and Gayatri mantra. The king asserted his authority over the three varnas. The Aitreya Brahmana refers to the Brahmana as the seeker of support and he could be removed by king from his position.

Certain craft groups managed to attain higher status. For example, the Rathakaras, the chariot makers, had the right to wear the sacred thread. Vaisya referred to the common people. They were involved in agriculture, cattle breeding and artisans. Later they became traders. Vaisyas paid tax to the kings. Some social groups were placed in ranking even below the Sudras.

The idea of *gotra* emerged in the later Vedic period. *Gotra* literally meant 'cowpen' and it referred to a group of people from a common

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